I've also had a proud association with Oakley eyewear for 14 years – another brand I'd buy if they didn't give me stuff. The designs are cutting edge and comfortable, and they've got lenses for every type of light – I can choose from more than 20 different lenses. I like wearing Oakley's new Jawbone range at the moment, and, man, have they been generous. I recently went to Oakley with Boucher – he was with Adidas eyewear, but is now also with Oakley – and I left with an armful of new shades.

Bouch was like, 'Jeez, Hersch, you can't leave here with 10 pairs!' I just laughed. 'Of course I can! I've been with Oakley the longest, my boy.' I also often go on their website, and if I see stuff I like, they'll organise it for me, even if it hasn't arrived in South Africa yet. Great bunch of people there!

The sponsor I've had for the longest, though, has been Gunn & Moore – we go back to even before the start of my international career. I use their bats, pads and gloves, and they really have been fantastic to me. Just to give you an example, they gave me a set of Ping golf clubs when I made my first international 100 … and quite a few sets since then too.

G&M tailor-make my bats specifically for me in the UK and then ship them out to wherever I am in the world. I'm using 212 (2 pounds 12 ounces) bats these days – I used to play with 208s and then 209s, but the way the game is going, you now need something heavier. I know Lance Klusener used to bat with a 213 or a 214, and rumours did the rounds that Graeme Pollock had batted with a three-pound bat. I don't know if that's true, as that is one bladdy heavy bat.

Bat making has evolved a great deal in recent years. Bats are still made of English willow, obviously, but the pick-up is now much better balanced. I can bat with a heavy bat with big, thick edges, but the pick-up – still the most important part of a bat's feel – makes it seem like it's a 208 or a 209.

However, the longevity of bats is becoming an issue these days. I was speaking to the guy who makes my bats at G&M and he was telling me how the cricket pros' bats just aren't lasting as long any more. With all the 20/20 and limited-over games these days, we aren't only playing more cricket, but also whacking the ball further and harder. Basically, the bats are getting knackered way more quickly.

Another factor: bowlers are all endlessly practising their limited-over death bowling, so you're facing yorker after yorker in the nets. The toe of